



Tagged and Tossed, Argued All the Same

A Shared Office Fridge’s QR-Label App Against Its Own Clear-Out Dispute Log

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The problem

Every shared office fridge accumulates unclaimed containers. A QR-label disposal app now schedules each item’s clear-out straight from its own printed use-by tag. Does a scheduled clear-out actually settle whose food got binned, or does it just relocate the argument?

What we set out to test

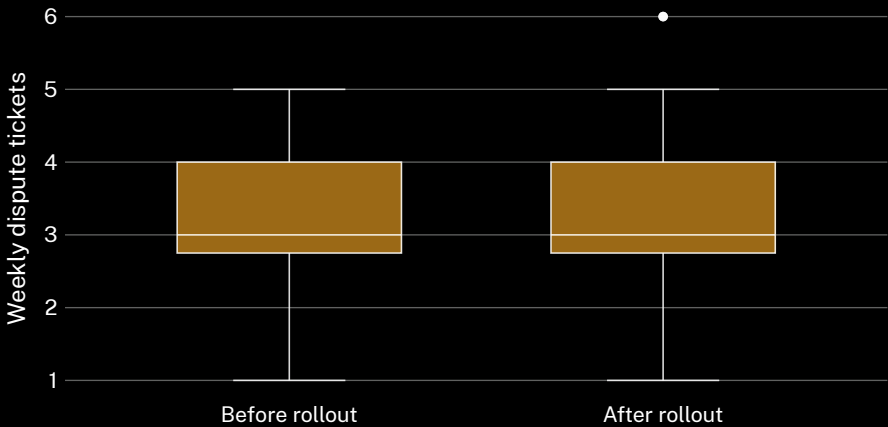
- Whether rising app-recorded label compliance tracks fewer Friday clear-out disputes
- Whether disputes shift from whose food it was to whether the tag was scanned
- Whether the paper roster it replaced settled disputes any differently

Approach

- n = 214 tagged items · 38 desks · 24 weeks pre/post rollout
- QR-scan disposal timestamps matched against Facilities’ dispute-ticket log
- Clear-out day held constant; only the calling mechanism changed

Results

Label compliance climbs from 61% to 94% within eight weeks of rollout. Weekly dispute-ticket counts show no corresponding shift across the same window.



Weekly dispute-ticket counts hold flat after rollout: median 3 both periods (IQR 2–4), 24 weeks each side, March–August 2026 — the two outlier weeks (6 tickets each) both followed a public holiday, not a compliance dip.

What it means

The app schedules who’s turn it was, not whose food it was. Compliance is the app’s own count; the dispute log is Facilities’. A rising percentage on one dashboard does not appear to reach the other. Desks report the same handful of disputed items each week, just now accompanied by a scan history nobody consults before raising a ticket. The scan record settles nothing a colleague’s memory of Tuesday’s lunch didn’t already settle; it only gives the argument a timestamp to cite, which desks cite anyway, selectively, in whichever direction the dispute already favours them. Next: whether the shared freezer, still on the old paper roster, quietly absorbs the difference the fridge no longer shows, and whether a second tag on the freezer door would just relocate it again.

Selected references

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3. Aitken, J. A., Mika, G., Alaybek, B., Leets, L., & Sprenger, A. (2025). An empirical comparison of informational and behavioral food waste interventions in U.S. households: The advantage of implementation intentions. *Sustainability*, 17(23). doi:10.3390/su172310752
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We thank the desks of the instrumented office kitchen for tolerating the audit, the app’s vendor for the raw scan export, and Facilities for backdating no tickets on our behalf.

De-identified scan and ticket timestamps only; no food contents assessed; no repeat offenders named.